

technologies like PHP, MySQL, etc. For me, it was a big learning experience. Apart from developing code, we had to work closely with the members of the business team, who were bringing us customer issues. The product was a consumer-facing portal that we were building. One had to turn around things very fast. If a customer wanted something, or even when preparing for a demo, one had to really slog through the day and night to make things happen; otherwise, it affected the cost of the business solution and there was revenue at stake. Our CEO was extremely hands-on. He would talk to us and guide us. I was the junior-most developer in the team. He would come and talk to me if I was working late in the night. This open culture and transparency gave me a lot of confidence about the quality of work I was producing.”

Plunging into bigger roles

Viswanath joined Microsoft in 2008. It was at a time when she had eight years of experience in the industry after having worked with Oracle in various roles. At that time, her goal was to work for a company where she would get to play bigger roles and broaden her scope of work. It was a different opportunity compared to what she had done in the past.

“I took it up as it was a large brand. Through my eight years at Microsoft, I had four different roles in two different units. It started from the licensing unit, which gave me exposure to how to build pricing and licensing models for a company. From there, I worked as a global accounts manager, on large accounts like Accenture, across India and APAC. I then moved to big market sales and after that to a partner management kind of role. Each role got me to push my limits and challenge myself as I entered newer domains. It was a very high paced environment at Microsoft,” says Viswanath.

Challenges and wins

Viswanath says that in her 20-year career, she faced many challenges. “The first challenge was figuring out what my capabilities were after the first five to eight years of work experience. During this time, you feel that you have the experience and you can do anything, but at the same time, though I felt I was ready for bigger roles, I was not getting the right opportunities within the company. I overcame that challenge by continuing to work with global leaders like Microsoft and tried to understand where my skill gaps were in order to make myself better,” says Viswanath. She adds, “Another challenge for me over my 20-year career, is that 90 per cent of it was spent in sales — pure sales, either enterprise or SaaS sales. But the role that I am in now at JFrog is different. It is not sales, but it is general management. It involves managing a site or a country for a growing company; managing teams for R&D; providing support to marketing, operations or finance; and building a sales team from scratch in India. I again wanted to do this for myself. I wanted to rediscover myself. It was my original goal of wanting to lead a company.”

Learning new things every day

Viswanath believes that selecting a career based on your gender is wrong. She asks youngsters to make this decision purely for the value it brings to one’s life.

She adds, “Evaluate whether you are truly interested in the field. You must be generally interested in it. You can’t look at it as purely something that is lucrative or that will give you a well-paying job. It must connect with you from within and then only you will be successful in the field. Being in tech is learning new things every day because technology is evolving so fast. One needs to keep reinventing oneself.”

India and women in tech

Viswanath feels that women have a great opportunity to shape the tech

landscape in India. She adds that she is not one of those who will tell women that one needs to network and find a mentor in the company in order to grow. “I think this applies to whatever kind of person you are — whether you are an extrovert who will go out and do this for yourself or an introvert who will show the value of your work to the company. The only thing I will say is that for the organisation to recognise your talent and reward you with the right kind of roles, you need to keep doing what you do and showcase your value in different ways. It could simply be contributing to a technology project, or taking up a project and offering to lead it. Second, one needs to spend some time in an organisation. The more time you spend in a company, the better are your chances of landing in a higher position because you know that culture and the business.”

The government needs to step up

Viswanath feels that from an education standpoint, the government needs to step up to update the curriculum, both in professional and school courses. India now does have a good amount of international schools that expose students to tech and tool-based learning, which helps a child to understand how to use these concepts in real life.

She concludes, “There is a big gap in what happens in the private realm of things, and what happens in those schools where the curriculum is governed and run by the government. The government should make the courses more relevant to today’s times. They need to introduce more tools, more experiment based learning, and not have just rote learning.”  END

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